

Focal point

A good painting has a strong focal point that immediately draws your eye to the main area of interest. The focal point of any image is the point where the lightest and darkest marks meet. You can use these tones elsewhere in your painting, but they

should only be next to each other where you want your viewer to focus. To emphasize the focal point even more, it is a good idea to restrict the range of tones you use for the details around it so that these areas are less defined and do not vie for attention.

LIGHT TO DARK

It is important to decide what your main point of interest is before you begin painting so that you can create a strong composition. Start by identifying the lightest colors in your composition. These colors lie underneath all the subsequent layers of color, unifying your picture. Block in these large areas of color first, then begin building up the mid-tones to give your painting structure. Next paint smaller, darker details, and finally, add tiny amounts of pure, bright color and the darkest tones of all to bring the main area of interest into focus.



Farm buildings The buildings have been brought into focus in this picture as dark foliage has been painted next to their light stonework. Flicking a small amount of complementary red paint in the foreground creates further interest.

BUILDING LAYERS

This painting of a flower pot has been built up in layers, starting with the lightest colors and then adding progressively smaller and darker areas of color so that detail and focus are established.

Light tones



For this painting, a mix of raw sienna and cadmium red was used first for the lightest tone.

Mid-tones



The mid-tones were then added. These create contrasts between objects and give them edges.

Dark tones



Mid dark details were painted, then dark accents added next to the lightest tones to create focus.